Common Health Conditions Guide

Plain-language information on everyday conditions: symptoms, home care and when to see a doctor

1. Fever

What is a fever? A fever is a body temperature of 38 degrees C (100.4 degrees F) or higher. Fever is a sign that the body is fighting an illness, most often an infection.

Common symptoms of fever: feeling hot or cold, shivering, sweating, headache, body aches, tiredness and loss of appetite.

Home care for fever: rest, drink plenty of fluids, wear light clothing and keep the room comfortable. Check any medicine label carefully and ask a doctor or pharmacist about the right medicine and dose, especially for children.

When to see a doctor for a fever: see a doctor if the fever lasts more than 3 days, is very high (above 39.4 degrees C or 103 degrees F), or comes with a stiff neck, severe headache, rash, confusion, trouble breathing, or repeated vomiting. A baby under 3 months old with a fever of 38 degrees C or higher needs urgent medical care.

2. Anemia

What is anemia? Anemia means the blood has too little haemoglobin, the part of red blood cells that carries oxygen. The most common cause worldwide is a lack of iron.

Symptoms of anemia: tiredness and weakness, pale skin, shortness of breath, dizziness, a fast heartbeat, headaches, and cold hands and feet.

Foods that help with anemia: iron-rich foods such as leafy green vegetables, lentils, beans, chickpeas, jaggery, dates, eggs, meat and fish. Vitamin C foods such as lemon, orange and amla help the body absorb iron. Tea and coffee taken with meals can reduce iron absorption.

Diagnosis and treatment of anemia: anemia is confirmed with a blood test. Do not start iron tablets on your own. A doctor will find the cause and decide the right treatment. Pregnant women, children and people with heavy periods are at higher risk and should get tested.

3. High blood pressure (hypertension)

What is high blood pressure? Blood pressure is the force of blood against the artery walls. A reading of 140/90 mmHg or higher on repeated checks is generally considered high, and some guidelines treat 130/80 mmHg as the starting point. High blood pressure often has no symptoms, so regular checks matter.

Risks of high blood pressure: if left untreated it raises the risk of heart attack, stroke, kidney disease and vision problems.

How to manage high blood pressure: eat less salt (the World Health Organization advises under 5 grams of salt a day), eat more fruit and vegetables, stay active for about 30 minutes on most days, keep a healthy weight, avoid tobacco, limit alcohol and manage stress. Take any prescribed medicine regularly and do not stop it without asking your doctor.

Emergency signs with high blood pressure: a very high reading together with chest pain, severe headache, shortness of breath, vision changes, weakness or confusion needs emergency care straight away.

4. Type 2 diabetes

What is type 2 diabetes? In type 2 diabetes the body does not use insulin properly, so sugar builds up in the blood. It usually develops slowly and is linked to excess weight, low physical activity and family history.

Symptoms of diabetes: extra thirst, passing urine often, constant hunger, tiredness, blurred vision, slow-healing cuts, frequent infections and unexplained weight loss. Some people have no symptoms at first.

Diagnosis of diabetes: diabetes is diagnosed with blood tests, such as fasting blood sugar and HbA1c. A fasting blood sugar of 126 mg/dL or more on two separate tests points to diabetes.

Managing diabetes: follow a balanced diet with less sugar and refined carbohydrates, walk or exercise regularly, keep a healthy weight, check blood sugar as advised, take medicines as prescribed and attend regular check-ups for the eyes, feet and kidneys.

Low blood sugar (hypoglycemia): shaking, sweating, hunger, dizziness and confusion can mean blood sugar is too low, mostly in people taking diabetes medicines. A person who is awake can take a fast sugar source such as glucose or sugary juice. If they are drowsy or unconscious, call emergency services.

5. Common cold and flu

Cold versus flu: a cold comes on gradually with a runny or blocked nose, sneezing and a sore throat. Flu (influenza) usually starts suddenly with fever, body aches, headache and strong tiredness. Both are caused by viruses.

Treating cold and flu: rest, drink warm fluids, gargle with warm salt water and use steam for a blocked nose. Antibiotics do not work against viruses and should not be used for colds or flu.

When to see a doctor for cold or flu: get medical help for trouble breathing, chest pain, a fever lasting more than 3 days, symptoms lasting more than 10 days, or if symptoms get worse after improving. People who are elderly, pregnant or have long-term illnesses should see a doctor early.

Preventing cold and flu: wash hands often, cover coughs and sneezes, stay home when sick, and ask your doctor about the yearly flu vaccine.

6. Dehydration and diarrhoea

Causes of dehydration: dehydration happens when the body loses more water than it takes in, for example through diarrhoea, vomiting, fever or heavy sweating in hot weather.

Signs of dehydration: thirst, dry mouth, dark yellow urine, passing little urine, dizziness and tiredness. In babies, look for a sunken soft spot on the head, no tears when crying and fewer wet nappies.

Treating dehydration with ORS: oral rehydration solution (ORS) is the main treatment for diarrhoea. Mix ORS powder with clean, safe water exactly as the packet says and sip it often. Continue normal

feeding and drink extra fluids. Zinc is recommended for children with diarrhoea as advised by a doctor.

When to see a doctor for diarrhoea: get medical help if there is blood in the stool, high fever, severe stomach pain, signs of dehydration, vomiting that stops fluids staying down, or diarrhoea lasting more than 2 days in adults. Babies and young children, and elderly people, should be seen sooner.

7. Dengue fever

What is dengue? Dengue is a viral infection spread by Aedes mosquitoes, which bite mainly during the day. It is common in India during and after the monsoon.

Symptoms of dengue: sudden high fever, severe headache, pain behind the eyes, muscle and joint pain, nausea, and sometimes a skin rash. Symptoms usually start 4 to 10 days after the bite.

Dengue warning signs: severe stomach pain, repeated vomiting, bleeding from the nose or gums, blood in vomit or stool, extreme tiredness or restlessness, and cold clammy skin, usually 3 to 7 days after the fever begins. These need immediate hospital care.

Care and prevention of dengue: rest and drink plenty of fluids. Do not take aspirin or ibuprofen for dengue unless a doctor tells you to, because they can raise the risk of bleeding. See a doctor for a blood test if you suspect dengue. To prevent it, remove standing water, use mosquito repellent and nets, and wear long sleeves.

Important: this document gives general health information for education. It cannot diagnose a condition or replace advice from a qualified doctor. If you are worried about your health, book an appointment with a doctor.